

Scoreboard		2.1 Speaker Sets (contd.)	
BRAND	Xfree	Zebronics	
Model	XE233	ZEB-SW8000	
Features (Out of 20)	9.20	11.04	
Power (RMS Watts): Subwoofer/Satellite	10/5	30/15	
Frequency Response	45 Hz–20 KHz	18 Hz–35 KHz	
Subwoofer Driver Diameter (Inches)	5	5.25	
Satellites Driver Diameter (Inches)	2.5	4	
Connectors on Subwoofer	RCA	RCA	
Controls Provided on Speaker Set/Remote Control			
Bass / Treble/Volume (Y/N)	✓/✗/✓	✓/✓/✓	
Others (List)	✗	✗	
Bundled Accessories			
Power Adapter (Y/N)	✗	✗	
Speaker Stands (Y/N)	✗	✗	
Remote Control (Wired / Wireless)	Wired	✗	
Batteries (Y/N/NA)	NA	NA	
Built-in Radio Tuner (AM/FM/N)	✗	✗	
Cables (List)	Stereo to Stereo Cable with Remote	Stereo to RCA, RCA to RCA	
Manual & Documentation (Y/N)			
Quick Setup Guide	✓	✓	
Troubleshooting	✗	✗	
Build Quality (So10)			
Knobs	6	6	
Speaker Veils	6	7	
Speaker Stands	0	0	
Overall Build Quality	6	8	
Performance (Out of 65)	24.54	30.26	
Music Quality (So10)			
Western			
Rock	5	5	
Jazz	5.5	6.5	
New Age	4.5	6	
Acid Trance	4	5.5	
Classical	4.5	5.5	
Indian			
Bollywood	4.5	4.5	
Bhangra	5	6	
Ghazal	5.5	5	
Classical Vocal	4.5	4.5	
Classical Instrumental	5.5	5	
DVD-Audio (Eric Clapton—Broken) (So10)			
Treble / Vocals / Bass	5/4.5/4	5/5/5	
DVD Movie Test (So10)			
Minority Report	3	5	
Behind Enemy Lines	3.5	4	
The Fast And The Furious	3	4	
Game Sound: Half-Life 2 (So10)	4	4	
Special Frequency Test Files (So10)			
50 Hz / 100 Hz	2/2	3/4	
250 Hz / 500 Hz	2/2	5/5	
1000 Hz / 15 KHz	2/1	5/1	
Power Handling: Bass / Treble (So10)	1/5	3/5	
Price Index (Out of 15)	8.48	7.61	
Price (Rs)	1,750	1,950	
Final Score (Out of 100)	42.22	48.91	
			
	+ None in particular - Poor performance	+ Decent for Western music - Large and heavy	

We received a 19 speaker sets in this category—from Altec Lansing, Artis, Creative, Intex, Logitech, Tech-Com, XFree, and Zebronics.

Features Power

Power rating is the most-vaunted parameter of a speaker set. For the layman, the power rating of a speaker set determines the loudness with which you can play sound. The power rating of PC speakers is generally specified in RMS wattage, but there were three Tech-Com speakers whose power was specified in PMPO. In case of 5.1 speaker sets, the power is the sum of the individual power ratings of the subwoofer, centre speaker, and the four satellites.

The Artis X10 Mini has the highest-powered subwoofer at 100 W and satellites at 28 W each. The next-highest powered speaker set was the Artis S8800, with an 80 W subwoofer and 20 W per satellite. The speakers from Creative and XFree were the lowest-powered, and therefore had problems handling sounds at a volume higher than 40 per cent.

Driver Size

A speaker with higher power usually has larger drivers. This is especially true in the case of subwoofers. An exception was the Altec Lansing FX5051, which was not high powered, but which had subwoofers with dual 6.5-inch drivers in isobaric configuration, thus effectively delivering double the bass levels without taking up additional floor space. High-powered speaker sets such as the Artis S8800, X10 Mini, and the Zebronics ZEB-SW13100R have huge 8-inch drivers, and this raised our expectations of getting some deeply immersive bass from them.

The satellites of most speaker sets consist of a single mid-range driver. But as you may be aware, a single driver can produce a limited range of frequencies. Therefore, speakers with more than one driver of different sizes are better, because they can deliver a larger range of frequencies. Such speakers included the Altec Lansing FX5051, Artis 6600R/FM, S8800 and X10 Mini, Intex IT-4800W, Tech-Com SSD-2001, SSD-5001, SSD-5101R and SSD-6001R, as well as the Zebronics ZEB-SW13100R.

Other Features

RCA was the most common connector type. RCA has the advantage of being less prone to noise, and it is resistant to damage. Stereo connectors, on the other hand, are prone to noise and damage. The Altec Lansing speakers were the only ones that accepted audio input via triple stereo pins. Clamp-type connectors, which connect directly to bare wires, are preferred by those who are not tolerant to audio noise. These connectors were found on a few models such as the Artis S5200, S8800 and X10 Mini, Tech-Com SSD-5101R and SSD-6001R, and the Zebronics ZEB-SW13100R.

The Altec Lansing FX5051 had a connector we didn't see on any other—a USB. Using this connector, you can listen to 5.1-channel audio from any computer with Windows 98 SE or higher. In this case, the audio signal is decoded